

CROSSWALK WISDOM

Your Sunk Cost Index

Personalized Reframe Guide

Understanding Your Score

SCORE 0–30	LOW ENTRAPMENT	You still have agency. Act now before sunk cost deepens.
SCORE 31–60	MODERATE ENTRAPMENT	Sunk cost is weighing on you. This is the moment to pivot.
SCORE 61–100	HIGH ENTRAPMENT	You're deep in the 4-layer trap. Reframing is urgent and possible.

No matter your score, the 4-layer trap is real and recognizable in your lived experience.

The 4-Layer Sunk Cost Trap

Layer 1: TIME

You've been on this path for years. Every year you stay compounds the feeling that leaving would be 'wasting' all that time. But time already spent cannot be recovered by staying. The only question is: where do you want the next years to go?

Layer 2: MONEY

Exams, applications, certifications, visa fees. You've spent tens of thousands of dollars chasing a credential that doesn't feel like 'you' anymore. The guilt is real. And that guilt is precisely what keeps you stuck—trying to justify the spend by staying in a role that's costing you everything else.

Layer 3: RELATIONSHIPS

How many relationships have bent under the pressure? Family who sacrificed. Friends who drifted. Partnerships that couldn't hold the weight of your schedule. Those losses are real. And they're another reason the mind says 'I can't walk away now—not after everyone gave this much.'

Layer 4: IDENTITY

This is the deepest layer. For years, your identity has been wrapped up in this role. Doctor. Nurse. Specialist. IMG. These titles became who you are. To leave feels like losing yourself entirely. But the version of 'you' that exists only in this role isn't whole—it's just what survived.

The 3-Step Reframe

Breaking free from sunk cost isn't about pretending the past didn't happen. It's about separating past investment from future choice.

Step 1: Name the Investment

Write down the 4 layers you've given: time, money, relationships, identity. Don't minimize it. The trap gets deeper when you try to pretend it wasn't that bad. Name it: 'I gave a lot. And I'm still empty.' This honesty is the foundation.

Step 2: Separate Past from Future

Every day you stay longer, you're asking the future to justify the past. But that's not how choice works. The past is fixed. The future is open. The only honest question is: 'Given where I am right now, what choice serves me going forward?' Not 'how do I justify what's already gone?'

Step 3: Choose Differently Today

You don't have to blow up your life. You start small. You say no to one extra shift. You reach out to one person. You spend one hour exploring what 'different' could look like. The reframe happens not in thought but in small acts of choosing yourself. Every choice compounds.

Living Authentically: What the Philosophers Say

Søren Kierkegaard: 'The Leap Into Authenticity'

Kierkegaard argued that authentic existence requires a 'leap of faith'—a moment where you stop calculating outcomes and choose yourself. You cannot reason your way to authenticity. At some point, you must act despite uncertainty. The IMG trapped in sunk cost is stuck in what Kierkegaard called 'the aesthetic mode'—constantly evaluating, comparing, justifying. Authenticity begins when you choose to leap.

Martin Heidegger: 'Authenticity vs. The They-Self'

Heidegger distinguished between the 'authentic self' and the 'they-self'—the version of you that exists only because of what 'they' expect. Most people live as the 'they-self,' making choices based on what 'one does' rather than what authentically matters. The trap of sunk cost is precisely this: you're living as the they-self, defending an identity that was never truly yours. Authenticity begins when you acknowledge this and choose differently.

Jean-Paul Sartre: 'Bad Faith and Freedom'

Sartre argued that humans are 'condemned to be free'—we have radical freedom in every moment. But we use 'bad faith' to deny it. Bad faith is saying: 'I can't leave because of what I've invested.' But this is a lie. You always have a choice. The moment you acknowledge your freedom—truly acknowledge it—is the moment you exit bad faith and enter authenticity.

Aristotle: 'Eudaimonia and the Good Life'

Aristotle defined the good life as living in alignment with your true nature. The problem with sunk cost is that it inverts this: you're sacrificing your flourishing to justify past investments. But the good life isn't about justifying the past—it's about developing virtue and excellence now. Every day you stay in a role that suffocates your nature is a day you're not flourishing. The cost isn't just financial; it's existential.

Marcus Aurelius: 'You Control What Comes Next'

The Stoic emperor Marcus Aurelius wrote: 'You have power over your mind—not outside events.' He wasn't denying that losses are real. He was saying that your power lies only in what comes next. You cannot change the years invested. But you can change your choice today. That choice is entirely within your power.

Hannah Arendt: 'Natality and New Beginnings'

Arendt emphasized that humans have the unique capacity for 'natality'—the ability to begin anew, to start fresh. You are not bound by your past investments. You have the capacity to begin again. Your past does not determine your future. Only you do.

Your 30-Day Authenticity Checklist

■ **Week 1:** Name the investment. Write down the 4 layers you've given (time, money, relationships, identity). Don't minimize.

■ **Week 1-2:** Tell one person the truth. 'I'm not okay. I've given more than I had to give.' This breaks the isolation.

■ **Week 2:** Identify one small way you can choose yourself this week. One shift you don't take. One conversation you have.

■ **Week 2-3:** Explore what 'different' could look like. Not as a plan. Just as a curiosity. What would bring you alive?

■ **Week 3-4:** Take the Fear Audit. Understand which fears are real obstacles and which are just stories.

■ **Week 4:** Make one concrete choice based on what you learned. Book a call. Apply. The choice proves the reframe is real.

What Comes Next

This guide is the reframe. The next step is the Fear Audit—a free assessment that goes beneath the sunk cost to the fears actually keeping you stuck. Most IMGs say: 'I didn't realize how much of my decision-making was fear-based until I saw it mapped out.'

After the Fear Audit, you'll understand not just whether you should stay or pivot—you'll understand what you're actually afraid of. And that changes everything.

The philosophers in this guide all point to the same truth: you are more free than you believe. The sunk cost is real, but it does not own your future. Only you do.

→ **Take the Fear Audit (free)**
www.crosswalkwisdom.com/fear-audit

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